

Basically, allowing themselves not to be limited due to the physical hardware of the smartphone.

Glass vs Keypad: War for future of smartphones

Before the launch of the iPhone in 2007, the smartphone market was dominated by all the Nokias, the BlackBerrys, and the Motorolas. All the devices made by these companies were very popular in the market, and they had something in common, which was the presence of a physical keyboard.

Phones with keyboards were a big thing in the early 2000s, and a major reason behind that was the rise of text messaging.

With the entire world being so big on texting, no one could imagine a phone without a physical keyboard at all. After the initial showcase of the iPhone, the world was split into two different opinions. While a large part of the media called the iPhone a revolution, at the same time, competitor brands were sure that the iPhone would never manage to take over. Simply because people were way too used to the feel of a physical keyboard.

The industry reactions included competitor brands like BlackBerry, simply thinking that the entire demo was a lie. They believed the giant 3.5" screen of the iPhone would eat the battery in minutes and that no one could actually type on glass.

Meanwhile, Microsoft's CEO at the time, Steve Ballmer, famously laughed during an interview, calling it "the most expensive phone in the world" and saying it wouldn't appeal to business users for its lack of a keyboard.

Jobs' logic of flexibility

The problem Steve Jobs had with the keyboard was that he didn't find the keyboard to be flexible; rather, he always found it to be hardware-limited. In his view, a physical button was a permanent commitment for a single function. It made total sense.



By moving the interface into software, Apple wanted the iPhone to have different personalities, so that it could change its entire personality based on the app you were using.

Different apps work differently; by sticking to the same physical keys, developers were overall limited by what they could do on the phone. Even with the keyboard itself, Jobs showed the power of a touchscreen keyboard.

He showed how they could change the keyboard based on the app. At the demo, he showed how the keyboard had added a ".com" button while using Safari, which would have been impossible on a physical keyboard.

Another reason why the iPhone was more flexible than the rest had majorly been due to the introduction of multi-touch. Before the iPhone, users interacted with the phone through either a stylus or a directional pad with a keyboard. But by killing the keyboard, Apple enabled direct manipulation. Using your own fingers felt much more natural.

Jobs famously introduced the multi-touch feature by talking about using our fingers as a touch input! He said, "It's the most accurate pointing device in the world, and it's a pointing device we're all born with"

Overcoming phone users' muscle memory

Another important aspect that Apple had to overcome with the removal of the keyboard was the muscle memory everyone had formed with their physical keyboards. Due to the rise of texting, everyone at the time became used to physical keyboards.

The raised ridges on a BlackBerry or the tactile "snap" of a Nokia keypad helped users fire off entire paragraphs without ever looking at the keyboard. So seeing Apple's decision to kill the physical keyboard, for many was the equivalent of trying to play a piano with no keys.

To tackle this muscle memory formed by most, Apple went full-on while designing the keyboard. The keys on the original iPhone had 3D shadows, and a "pop-up" animation when touched, which signalled the brain that this is a button you can press. It gave the brain the tactile feedback that the fingers were missing due to the lack of a physical keyboard. The keyboard sound, helped a lot during the early days, as it was used to tackle the tactile feedback of the physical keyboard. **d**

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